The Clockmaker of Lantern Street

On the corner of Lantern Street, where the cobblestones dipped like a sleeping cat's back, stood a tiny shop with a crooked sign that read Amir's Clocks and Other Small Wonders. Amir had run the shop for forty years. Every morning he unlocked the door at exactly seven, wound the great brass clock in the window, and set a kettle on the little stove behind the counter. Every morning the street woke to the sound of his clocks, hundreds of them, all ticking slightly out of step with one another, like rain on a tin roof.

Nobody in the neighborhood could remember a time when the shop was closed. Children stopped at the window on their way to school to watch the tiny wooden bird in the cuckoo clock pop out and bow. If a watch stopped, a pocket watch, a wristwatch, even a pendant on a grandmother's chain, people brought it to Amir, and he would peer at it through his round glasses and say the same thing every time. "It is not broken, my friend. It is only tired."

One rainy Tuesday in October, a girl came into the shop. She was perhaps eleven years old, with wet braids and a backpack too large for her shoulders. She stood by the door and dripped on the mat, saying nothing, while Amir finished oiling a tiny gear. When he finally looked up, she held out her closed hand and opened it slowly. In her palm lay a small silver watch, its glass cracked and its hands frozen at ten minutes past four.

"It was my grandfather's," she said. "He told me it would keep working as long as I kept it safe. But I dropped it on the stairs, and now it won't move." "My name is Zara. Can you fix it? I only have three dollars."

Amir took the watch gently, as one might lift a sparrow. He turned it over, studied the back, and pressed his thumbnail against the tiny latch. The case clicked open. Inside, the gears were bright and clean, and not a single one was broken. He looked at the girl over his glasses. "Sit down, Zara," he said. "Tea will help. Repairs of this kind cannot be hurried."

She sat on a stool beside the stove while the kettle began to sing. Amir worked in silence for a long while, using tweezers so fine they seemed like the legs of an insect. Zara watched his steady hands and slowly stopped shivering.

At last Amir set down his tools. "I have good news and strange news," he said. "The good news is that the watch is not damaged. The spring is perfect. The gears are perfect. The strange news is that it stopped for a reason." He held it up so the lamplight caught the silver. "A watch like this does not stop by accident, Zara. It stops when the person who winds it has stopped winding it. Tell me, when did your grandfather last wind it?"

Zara stared at the floor. For a moment the only sound was the clocks. "He passed away in the spring," she whispered. "I took the watch from his drawer. I was afraid to wind it. I thought if I did, it might break, and then I would lose the last thing he touched." She wiped her eyes with her sleeve. "So I kept it in my pocket and never wound it. And then I dropped it, and I thought I had ruined everything."

Amir was quiet. He poured two cups of tea and slid one across the counter. "Do you know why I love clocks?" he asked. She shook her head. "Because a clock is a promise. Every tick says, I am still here, and the next moment is coming. But a clock cannot keep that promise alone. Someone must wind it, again and again, day after day. The winding is the love. The ticking is only the proof."

He placed the watch in her palm and showed her the small brass crown on its side. "Turn it gently, ten times, no more. Never force it. If you feel it resist, stop." Zara's fingers trembled as she turned the crown. One, two, three. She counted aloud, and by seven the watch began to hum against her skin, a soft and living sound. At ten, the second hand quivered, hesitated, and then began to move.

Zara laughed, and then she was crying, and then she was laughing again. "Now the hands show the wrong time," he said, once she had calmed. "Set them to match the clock in the window." She pulled out the crown and carefully moved the hands forward, until they agreed with the great brass clock, and the little watch ticked in time with the whole shop.

She reached into her backpack and counted out three crumpled dollars. "The repair was free," he said. "But I will ask one thing in return. Come back every Tuesday and tell me the time. I am an old man, and my own watch is always a minute slow."

So every Tuesday after school, Zara came to Lantern Street. At first she only visited to wind her grandfather's watch, but soon she was learning the names of the tools, the sizes of the screws, and the secrets of the pendulum. By summer she was fixing the

cuckoo clock herself, and the little wooden bird bowed to her as though it knew.

Years later, when Amir grew too old to climb the shop's narrow stairs, the sign above the door was repainted. It now read Amir and Zara, Clocks and Other Small Wonders. Every morning, the girl who was no longer a girl unlocked the door at exactly seven, wound the great brass clock in the window, and set the kettle on the stove. And every morning, on a chain around her neck, a small silver watch ticked softly against her heart, keeping its promise, one winding at a time.